UP—where Rajbhar votes matter in at least a dozen Lok Sabha seats. The western UP-based RLD, whose chief Jayant Chaudhary recently cut ties with I.N.D.I.A., got its recompense for hitching its wagon of Jat votes to the NDA.

The other two cabinet inductees were BJP leaders brought in to balance the caste arithmetic—OBC leader and Lonia Rajput fixture Dara Singh Chauhan, and Sunil Sharma, the MLA from Sahibabad in west UP, whose Brahmin brethren were apparently peeved at his exclusion. Dara, who rejoined the BJP in 2023 after another one of his excursions, too, has got his "return gift", as a BJP leader put it. With these additions, the UP council of ministers goes up to 56 members, including 18 of cabinet rank. This partly eases the pressure on

RAJBHAR POINTS OUT THAT THE SBSP CONTESTED ALONE IN 2019, WHICH IS WHY "THE BJP SUFFERED IN PURVANCHAL"

seats—for the BJP, it's easier to buy the affection of small allies like the SBSP, Nishad Party and RLD with ministerial berths than to part with precious seats at this crucial stage.

The Samajwadi Party, UP's major I.N.D.I.A. player, is also wooing smaller parties from the other side. The SP-Congress bloc now has with it the Apna Dal (Kamerawadi), a splinter faction of the late Sonelal Patel's party, and will most likely be joined by Bhim Army chief Chandrashekhar's Azad Samaj Party (ASP). Two more parties are reportedly in touch with I.N.D.I.A.—the Mahan Dal, Keshav Dev Maurya's OBC-based outfit, which has a footprint in central UP, and the Babu Singh Kushwaha-led Jan Adhikar Party, with its presence in Bundelkhand.

Rajbhar knows he can afford to talk tough: he claims his SBSP can help the NDA increase its tally by at least half a dozen seats. Talking to INDIA TODAY, he said, "The Rajbhars make up 3 per cent of the population, but, in east UP, we have significant numbers in 28 seats and can influence the results in 12, including Ballia, Ghazipur and Azamgarh. We can help the BJP win the seats they lost in 2019, particularly Ghazipur, Lalganj and Ghosi. We make up over 12 per cent of the voters in these seats." He pointed out that the SBSP had left the NDA and contested on its own in 2019, which is why "the BJP suffered in Purvanchal". Sanjay Nishad, cabinet minister in the Yogi government and Nishad Party chief, also makes similar claims: "We have influence in Gorakhpur, Sant Kabir Nagar, Bansgaon and even in Varanasi. The BJP knows our worth."

Incidentally, most of these small OBC outfits were fierce critics of the "Bania-Brahmin BJP" early on when they sprouted. Some are offshoots of the Bahujan Samaj Party, which in the 1990s emerged as a rallying point for the backward castes who felt left out in the post-Mandal political matrix. Both Rajbhar and Sonelal Patel were once close aides of the late Kanshi Ram, BSP's charismatic founder. Sonelal quit the BSP in 1996 and founded the Apna Dal, while Rajbhar formed his own party in 2002 after a fallout with Mayawati.

The Nishad community mostly voted the SP or the BSP while following in the footsteps of their lodestar, the late bandit queen-turned-neta Phoolan Devi. The BJP roped them in as an ally

CASTEING A WIDE NET

Small parties with a hold on caste cohorts are much in demand this poll season

NDA BLOC

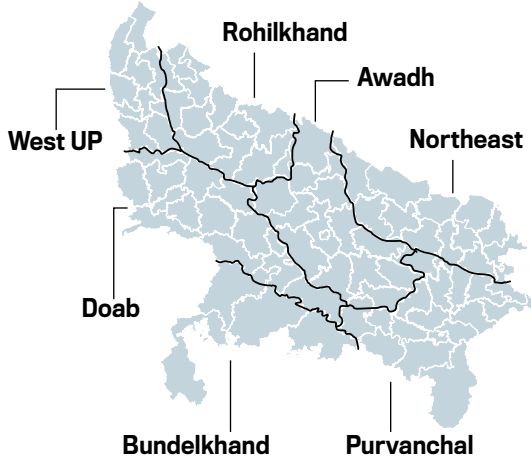
APNA DAL (S) 2*
Anupriya Patel
East UP (Purvanchal), including Varanasi, Mirzapur, Chandauli

SBSP 1*
O.P. Rajbhar
East UP, including Ballia, Ghosi, Ghazipur

RLD 2*
Jayant Chaudhary
West UP, including Muzaffarnagar, Baghpat, Mathura

NISHAD PARTY 1*
Sanjay Nishad
East UP, including Gorakhpur, Sant Kabir Nagar, Bhadohi

** LS seats allotted*



I.N.D.I.A. BLOC

APNA DAL (K)
Pallavi Patel
East UP, including Kaushambi, Prayagraj and Pratapgarh
Seats unconfirmed

LIKELY TO JOIN AZAD SAMAJ PARTY
Chandrashekhar Azad
West UP, including Bijnor, Saharanpur, Bulandshahr